

SWEPT AWAY
A woman mourns her lost home after a cloudburst in Kishtwar district, Aug. 15

Bhagwant Mann—speaking from a hospital bed in Mohali, where he was admitted on September 5 with viral fever—announced his cabinet's long-awaited flood relief package. The irony wasn't lost on many: while the CM recuperated, the state had yet to begin its special *girdawari* (damage survey) to map the destruction. Still, the plan was unveiled: Rs 20,000 per acre for crop loss along with promises of various policy reliefs. On paper, Punjab's proposal may look substantial, but on the ground it feels woefully inadequate. "Rs 20,000 barely covers input costs. We expected at least Rs 40,000 per acre," says Satwant Singh of Gurchak. Tenant farmers, who form a large but invisible part of Punjab's agrarian economy, face a double blow: without formal contract norms, they are not eligible for compensation. "This relief doesn't recognise us," says Balkar Singh of Ajnala. The Centre has announced relief of Rs 1,600 crore for Punjab and similar amounts for the other states. But that's barely a speck, says the Mann government.

HIMACHAL'S VALLEYS OF WOES

The Himalayan state has seen the worst of it, with 76 days of extreme weather in the June 1-September 1 phase. Cloudbursts contributed to the deadly mix unleashed by torrential downpours from mid-August in the hills, putting the dams—Pong on the Beas and Bhakra Nangal on the Sutlej—to severe test. The spate of landslides in August-September has reopened old wounds over the follies of construction on the steep slopes, with villages in Kullu, Mandi, Chamba, Kinnaur and Shimla districts being buried under mud and debris. Tourist favourite Manali was cut off, the strategic Manali-Leh road was closed and thousands of tourists were stranded. In Chamba district, the Pathankot highway was blocked near Nalda bridge, while the suspension of the annual Manimahesh Yatra stranded over 5,000 pilgrims. Shimla had 828 road closures and three bridges washed away. For fruit